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their empires against colonized populations eager for freedom. The newly independent nations became an ideological and even, at times, military battleground between the capitalist and communist systems.

In the end, the issue was settled by economics. Capitalism showed its ability to generate economic growth on a vast scale, creating a booming consumer society in more advanced countries. In contrast, by the 1980s communist countries confronted economic stagnation and rising popular discontent. With great rapidity, communist regimes collapsed in the Soviet bloc, while communist China later became a powerhouse of capitalism.

In the wake of communism, the political scientist Francis Fukuyama coined the expression the “end of history” and argued that Western liberal democracy was “the only game in town.” Certainly, by the end of the 20th century liberalism was surfing a wave: in 1950, only a few nations in Europe were democracies; 50 years later, all of them were.

Progress and pessimism

From the 1960s, hotly contested campaigns for civil rights had progressed liberal ideals in areas such as racial equality and gender

politics. Growing prosperity was also impressive. In Latin America and much of Asia, living standards had risen dramatically by the early 21st century. Despite the world’s population increasing on a huge scale—from under 2 billion in 1914 to over 7 billion one century later—food supplies had not run out, as had once been predicted by many. Restricting environmental damage was recognized as a major challenge for the future, a problem generated by humanity’s growth and success.

Indeed, human progress in the 20th century was remarkable, from rising literacy and life expectancy to the development of air and space travel and computers. Yet there was no outbreak of general optimism. Environmental issues aside, it was all too evident that the future held potential dangers: the unsettled politics of the Middle East, sucking major powers into wars; brutal acts of terrorism; economic inequality generating mass migration; financial instability and market breakdown; epidemics spread by global travel—all provided plenty of material for pessimists. History offered no solid ground for predictions, suggesting only that the unexpected was to be expected. ■